

CONDEMNED: Prisoners (right) who have been sentenced to death at Bhagalpur Central Jail



ANGMAN

though the Bhagalpur jail had already received a black warrant. An execution should be carried out within the 28th day of the issuance of a black warrant. The date of his hanging was also fixed, between June 4 and June 12, before it was finally "postponed", perhaps for the last time.

Another condemned prisoner, Shobhit Chamar, has been waiting for the inevitable since February 23, 1996, after being awarded death sentence for murder. There are many others like Dharmender alias Dharo, Veer Kunwar Paswan, Krishna Mochi and Nandal Mochi, who were sentenced to death on



Many convicts on death row are pinning their hopes on clemency petitions filed before the President.

NOT IN USE: Tin sheets now cover the gallows at Bhagalpur jail



July 8, 2001 for committing Bihar's most gruesome massacre, the Bara carnage, in which 36 upper caste landlords were butchered to death, but are waiting for their clemency plea to be heard.

The postponement of Prajit's execution, meanwhile, has given the state prison officials some breathing space for outsourcing two hangmen from other states. In fact, the Bhagalpur jail authorities have already sent an sos to state prison headquarters which too is working overtime in search of an executioner since local hangmen have put up impossible preconditions in lieu of tightening the noose this time. Jagua

Dome, the sweeper-turned-hangman, who had executed Bahri in 1995, is no more. Before Jagua, it was prison sweeper Damodar who had executed two murder convicts, Paramhans Yadav and Bhola Shah in 1988, and now wants a "permanent job" in lieu of pulling the lever—something that no prison authorities can promise. "We have a provision in the jail manual that allows us to employ a convict as a hangman," says S.K. Ambastha, assistant inspector-general (prisons). He, however, admits that nobody, not even a convict, can be forced to take up a hangman's job. And even if prison officials are somehow able to persuade Damodar, they will still need a standby hangman. In fact, Jagua's son Laadu was approached by the prison officials to join as standby executioner. He, in return, sought a government job, Rs 50,000 in cash and armed bodyguards. Laadu is particular about the government job because his father "had become withdrawn after hanging Bahri" and was stripped of his job six months after performing the execution.

"We will go by the book," says Paundrik, adding, "in last few years, no one had been awarded death sentence in the state so the need for a hangman never arose. But we will find one if the situation demands." Meanwhile, Afzal Ammanullah, principal secretary, home, says, "If required, Bihar would hire hangmen from outside the state." In the absence of executions in Bhagalpur jail, the elevated circular platform with a gaping hole in the middle, which is located very close to the isolated enclosure where the condemned prisoners stay, is now covered with corrugated iron sheets. The gibbet and the plank used as the trap door are kept in safe custody and a door to the well, that is used to retrieve the body, too has been locked since 1995.

Bihar may be facing a dearth of hangman, but it produces the executioner's rope in plenty. Buxar jail, is probably the only one in the country manufacturing Manila rope, weighing 3.75 kg, 60 ft in length and priced at nearly Rs 2,000—which is good enough to withstand the fall of a man sent to the gallows. However, the demand for Buxar jail's famed rope has diminished as there are fewer executions now. ■